Decompose the Task

Monday Moments · AI Fluency · Week 4

How do we make a large task inspectable before we rush into it?

Break a vague task into bounded stages with visible interfaces and checkpoints.

Today's finish line

DO THIS See the core move.

WHAT THIS MEANS
Separate the whole goal from the stages, dependencies, and checks that make progress visible.

DO THIS Try it on a bounded example.

WHAT THIS MEANS
Build a small course landing page: context $\rightarrow$ content $\rightarrow$ links $\rightarrow$ mobile check $\rightarrow$ publish decision.

DO THIS State evidence and limits.

WHAT THIS MEANS
A staged plan, one interface/checkpoint per stage, and a reason to revise.

What does this prove, and what does it not prove?

DO THIS → WHAT THIS MEANS → FIND THIS YOURSELF → DEMAND DOCUMENTATION
VERIFY ON YOUR MACHINE → KEEP THE RECEIPT

The mental model

The idea

A decomposition is a map from one whole task to smaller bounded stages. Each stage should have a purpose, an input, an output, and a checkpoint.

The boundary

More boxes do not make a plan safer. If stages hide dependencies or omit the user's goal, decomposition has created ceremony, not clarity.

FIND THIS YOURSELF Before accepting a conclusion, name the observation that would support it.

A worked computing example

DO THIS Apply the idea to this bounded case: Build a small course landing page: context $\rightarrow$ content $\rightarrow$ links $\rightarrow$ mobile check $\rightarrow$ publish decision.

First pass

- What is known now?
- Which step or assumption is visible?
- Where is the checkpoint?

Professional move

Start with the student's goal, then name the content needed, the stable routes, the rendering check, and the decision point before publishing.

Label the application: This is an instructor/computing translation, not a claim about the primary source.

Ask before the answer

How do we make a large task inspectable before we rush into it?

Predict
What would you expect if the first story were incomplete?

Compare
What alternative explanation deserves a fair test?

PAIR TALK: Make one claim, one reason, and one uncertainty visible.

Do this: make the move visible

DO THIS Write the whole task first. Circle the first irreversible or uncertain step, then split only where a new boundary improves inspection.

1. Write the task, decision, or claim in one sentence.
2. Mark the relevant stages, evidence, comparison, or criteria.
3. Choose one checkpoint before you act or explain.
4. Say what would make you revise, stop, or continue.

VERIFY ON YOUR MACHINE A good first attempt leaves a receipt another person can inspect.

What the source supports — and its limits

Supports

- Decomposition can expose interfaces, missing context, dependencies, risks, and verification points before implementation.
- A clearer question and a more bounded next move.

Does not prove

A plan is a hypothesis, not proof that the work will succeed; decomposition does not remove judgment, testing, or changing requirements.

Is this safe? Is this secure?

How do I know? Where can I verify that?

Recovery: when the first story fails

PAUSE

A failed check is information about the route.

Use one bounded recovery

1. Preserve the observation and context.
2. Name the assumption or step to inspect.
3. Make one smaller retry or ask for help.
4. Do not turn uncertainty into a confident story.

Watch for: A component inventory with no whole-task goal, or a “test it” step with no concrete case.

Keep the receipt

DO THIS Record the smallest useful evidence.

- Claim or decision
- Observation and context
- Reasoning / comparison / checkpoint
- Result, limit, and next action

Exit move

Name one task you will decompose, its first checkpoint, and the observation that would make you revise the route.

KEEP THE RECEIPT A concise receipt beats a confident story.

Your next move

Name one task you will decompose, its first checkpoint, and the observation that would make you revise the route.

How will you know?